THE SPLIT BIBLE

The above description of the canonisation of the Bible, and the creation of the Mishnah and Talmud, ignores one very important fact. The process of canonising the word of Jehovah created not one chain of texts but several competing chains. There were people who believed in Jehovah, but not in the rabbis. Most of these dissenters did accept the first block in the biblical chain – which they called the Old Testament. But already before the rabbis sealed this block, the dissenters rejected the authority of the entire rabbinical institution, which led them to subsequently reject the Mishnah and Talmud, too. These dissenters were the Christians.

When Christianity emerged in the first century CE, it was not a unified religion, but rather a variety of Jewish movements that didn't agree on much, except that they all regarded Jesus Christ – rather than the rabbinical institution – as the ultimate authority on Jehovah's words.[40] Christians accepted the divinity of texts like Genesis, Samuel and Isaiah, but they argued that the rabbis misunderstood these texts, and only Jesus and his disciples knew the true meaning of passages like 'the Lord himself will give you a sign: the *almah* will conceive and give birth to a son, and will call him *Immanuel*' (Isaiah 7:14). The rabbis said *almah* meant 'young woman', *Immanuel* meant 'God with us' (in Hebrew *immanu* means 'with us' and *el* means 'God'), and the entire passage was interpreted as a divine promise to help the Jewish people in their struggle against oppressive foreign empires. In contrast, the Christians argued that *almah* meant 'virgin', that *Immanuel* meant that God will literally be born among humans, and that this was a prophecy about the divine Jesus being born on earth to the Virgin Mary.[41]

However, by rejecting the rabbinical institution while simultaneously accepting the possibility of new divine revelations, the Christians opened the door to chaos. In the first century CE, and even more so in the second and third centuries CE, different Christians came up with radically new interpretations for books like Genesis and Isaiah, as well as with a plethora of new messages from God. Since they rejected the authority of the rabbis, since Jesus was dead and couldn't adjudicate between them, and since a unified Christian church didn't yet exist, who could decide which of all these interpretations and messages were divinely inspired?

Thus, it was not just John who described the end of the world in his Apocalypse (the book of Revelation). We have many additional apocalypses